Occasionally I remember scenes from certain films or have a sudden appreciation of the noise of the crowd. That's not a great sign, because it suggests the bubble of concentration has been punctured. My instinct is to identify the problem, accept what has happened, reorganize and reset. You will never fight it, because the brain can take you to random places. When you are playing well, you soon return to reality. When you are not in good nick, you're struggling for control.

That's when easy conversation with the bloke at the other end is important. It brings you back to the moment, delivers a reminder that it's the two of you against the world. It is a marriage of sorts. You get to know each other's funny little ways and learn to adjust. The manipulation of small targets is a common way to cope. Trotty, for instance, compulsively built his innings in five-run blocks.

Each to his own. The problem comes when errors are contagious. I'm fascinated by the psychology of batting collapses, even though it is one of the hardest phenomena to discuss openly, because doing so can be regarded as an admission of collective weakness. A dressing room doesn't usually have a Corporal Jones, barking out, 'Don't panic, Captain Mainwaring.' It is inclined to be eerily quiet.

Supporters share the paranoia. Whoever they follow, they are convinced their team is more prone to collapse than most. It's illogical, since with the occasional exception, we are all pretty much of a muchness. It's difficult to explain, but cricket isn't an academic exercise, an application of Artificial Intelligence. It is a game played by human beings, who are susceptible to mood and momentum.

It is simple to identify the problem, by the repetition of common sense. Don't lose wickets in clusters. That might appear to be a statement of the obvious, but to recap, that's exactly why I was immediately apologetic after being dismissed in my last Test innings. Joe Root and I had lazily put the onus on Jonny Bairstow and Ben Stokes to rebuild. They were subjected to unnecessary pressure.

Here's the way things can go: you've got a steady partnership, forty or fifty or so, and you're at the other end when your partner gets out. Suddenly you've got a new face in, and for no apparent reason you feel differently. Is it pressure? It is certainly a trick of the mind. Logically, you don't immediately lose shape or form. You know you've been batting well, but your mind is telling you that you can't get out, that you must not get out.